



### IT'S 1 AM IN A STILL, MUGGY NIGHT in Delhi.

In a corner of the city, at the Aerocity area near the international airport, Khubani in Andaz Delhi hotel is brimming with people decked in their swankiest attires. Men and women sway to the soft, soulful music wafting through the place, with some looking in from the balcony of what you might describe as a ballroom. Each patron seems to be in thrall of the song being sung by a Sufi singer. While the crowd is mesmerised by the melody, people in uniform are busy weaving through those swaying to the music, serving drinks and snacks among the patrons. Even the bar is bustling with orders.

The stream of people coming in to enjoy every Wednesday evening's Sufi rendition doesn't stop till late into the night. "We enjoy coming to the outlet, which is safe and where we can enjoy at night. Sometimes, we want to stay beyond 1 am but the bar staff starts pushing us to leave, and that irks us," says a couple who frequents Khubani and other similar outlets.

Khubani is one of the few nightclubs in Delhi that remain open late into the night. "You can count outlets like Khubani on your fingertips in Delhi. Being the national capital, Delhi is still very far from becoming a night-time economy," says Sharad Madan, Co-founder of Imperfecto and Khubani. Madan owns 12 such establishments in Delhi and Gurugram, and says that there are hardly any people out having a good time in Delhi after 1

am. However, when you travel across the world, the party begins at night.

But the case for a night-time economy is not only to cater to the demand of revelers. The former Night Mayor of Amsterdam, Mirik Milan, once said: "Late night culture is a massive motor for a city's economic well-being." Meanwhile, the night-time culture in India is a little different. As people in the megacities of the country seek the warmth of their beds, even the parts of the economy that can function at night, and add substantial value to the overall economy, go into a slumber. But there are some pockets in the country where a night-time economy is an evolving phenomenon.

The latest stride in this direction has been taken by Haryana. To compete with New Delhi's new liquor policy that looks to upgrade the city's liquor vends and intensify competition among private players (the policy was recently rolled back), Haryana has given bars and restaurants an option to operate 24x7 across cities in the state. According to its new liquor policy, there will be no cap on timings for outlets that pay an additional liquor licence fee of ₹20 lakh per annum. However, pubs and restaurants that would like to close their establishments at 2 am instead of 1 am can operate on older licences, and pay the usual annual liquor licence fee of ₹18 lakh. The new policy allows for pubs and restaurants to start serving liquor from 8 am, while the old policy that was modified in April this year extended the closing time for pubs and restaurants from 1 am to 2 am.

Vikrant Batra, owner of the Cafe Delhi Heights chain—that has not opted for the new 24x7 regime introduced by the Haryana government—says that extending the closing time of cafes and bars from 1 am to 2 am has resulted in a revenue hike of over 25 per cent for them. "Just an extension of one hour has resulted in a steep revenue rise, and an increase in job creation by 15 per cent. Imagine if we are allowed to be open through the night [without the need for an additional licence], what kind of boost it will give to our revenue, and subsequently to our nation's economy as well," he adds.

But the liquor policies of state gov-

## 5-10

### PER CENT

THE EXPECTED GROWTH IN THE HOSPITALITY SECTOR IF IT IS ALLOWED TO OPERATE THROUGH THE NIGHT

SOURCE INDUSTRY